

L^AT_EX for Medieval Primary Source Handouts

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The world's best established software system for typesetting and document formatting, L^AT_EX has been popular throughout the mathematical and physical sciences for decades. The utility of L^AT_EX for scholars in humanities disciplines, however, tends to be overlooked.

L^AT_EX can be used for typesetting in (almost) all instances in which a scholar of humanities needs to present our materials elegantly.

I have prepared these slides in L^AT_EX – more quickly and with less frustration than would have been possible in graphical presentation program (e.g. LibreOffice Present).

This Tutorial

In this tutorial, I will introduce attendees to the use of LaTeX for a common task in medievalist scholarship, namely, typesetting texts with unusual line length and other organizational needs, such as primary texts with our original translations.

The specific example will be preparing a handout for a historical conference or class presentation with perfectly organized excerpts of a Byzantine Greek text and an original English translation in parallel.

I will walk attendees in sequence through setup, formatting, and, finally, viewing a document of this kind – talking about different approaches that one might take depending on needs, such as placing right-to-left (notably, Semitic) and left-to-right languages side-by-side.

I aim to inspire attendees to think about L^AT_EX as a highly flexible tool with a wider range of professional applications than it often is understood as having.

What is L^AT_EX?

It might be best to start to understand what L^AT_EX *is* by understanding what it is *not*.

A word processor, such as LibreOffice Writer or Microsoft Word, presents material in a (W)hat (Y)ou (S)ee (I)s (W)hat (Y)ou (G)et (WYSIWYG, “whizzy-wig”) style. While one writes, one is simultaneously thinking about and working on formatting.

In a typesetting language, such as L^AT_EX (or ConT_EXt or T_ypst, among others), one is only concerned about the *structure* of what one is writing. One declares that specific characters will be in certain categories of writing ‘things’ (heading, paragraph, footnote, accent type, typeface, etc.), and one allows the program to compile one’s writing as ‘code’ into a tidy final document – every time.

Getting Started with $\text{\LaTeX}$ in GNU/Linux

- ▶ latex-project.org
 - ▶ official recommendations for $\text{\LaTeX}$ **distributions**
 - ▶ $\text{\LaTeX}$ **distributions** are community-maintained bundles of closely interrelated software, including the $\text{\TeX}$ backend, $\text{\LaTeX}$ itself, and hundreds to thousands of packages that extend $\text{\LaTeX}$'s functionality
- ▶ *BSD or GNU/Linux? **TeXLive**
- ▶ MacOS? **MacTeX**
- ▶ Microsoft Windows? **TeXLive** or **MiKTeX**

TeXLive is available in the official package repositories of most *BSD and GNU/Linux operating systems. To install the complete TeXLive distribution (which the $\text{\LaTeX}$ project recommends for newcomers) on one of the most popular libre Unix-like operating systems, one could type:

Debian/Ubuntu

```
apt install texlive-full
```

Fedora

```
dnf install texlive-scheme-full
```

Arch

```
yay -S texlive-meta
```

FreeBSD

```
pkg install texlive-full
```

Setting Parallel Text in L^AT_EX

TeXLive, MiKTeX, and other L^AT_EX distributions ship with the package called `parallel`. For full documentation, visit:

ctan.org/pkg/parallel

To start using `parallel` in any L^AT_EX document, simply include the following in the preamble:

```
\usepackage{parallel}
```


For example, here is an abbreviated form of the preamble to this Beamer (L^AT_EX presentation class) file with the four most important entries:

```
\documentclass{beamer}
\usetheme{Goettingen}
\usepackage{listings}
\usepackage{parallel}
```